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31 August 2026

Dear Hiring Manager,

The Knowledge Paralegal role in A&O Shearman's Global Financial Markets Group is the role I most want at this stage of my career. My interest in finance work started concretely at A&O Shearman's open day in August 2026, where I attended a private equity session and a finance workshop covering how different practice groups contribute to a PE transaction and how lenders take security over assets including aircraft and ship financing. That session prompted me to take a Coursera course on private equity, where I studied fund structures, leverage, value creation and exit strategies to understand the commercial mechanics behind the legal work. I then completed the Clifford Chance Real Estate Finance virtual programme to apply financing and security concepts in a transactional context. GFM is where that developing interest leads next, and A&O Shearman is specifically where I want to pursue it.

On the knowledge and research side, my strongest evidence comes from my LLM dissertation, which received a Distinction (75%) and examined how GDPR has developed across jurisdictions. Researching a fast-moving, technically complex area of law across multiple legal systems required me to identify the right sources, track doctrinal development carefully and produce analysis that was precise rather than general. That kind of structured legal research into evolving regulatory and market frameworks is directly relevant to supporting a knowledge function in a practice group where market practice itself is shaped by the team's work.

At BCLP I developed the organisational discipline that knowledge and document management work requires. During an international investment arbitration, I became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant procedural deadline. I coordinated outstanding documents, tracked actions across the matter and helped ensure on-time submission. I also maintained structured electronic case files, coordinated translated documents with an external translator, and liaised directly with the client on required materials. A partner and associate told me my performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor. Managing competing priorities under genuine time pressure, across a complex matter with multiple stakeholders, is something I have done in a serious professional context.

A&O Shearman's GFM team shapes market practice on high-profile deals. A knowledge paralegal role within that team, supporting the infrastructure that enables the team to work at that level, is a specific and meaningful opportunity to build real expertise in finance law from the inside. That is why I am applying to this role and not to a generic finance paralegal position elsewhere.

Yours sincerely,
Maria Silva